Hi All,
here are some ramblings that may or may not be accurate and may or may not provide some guidance for Alice Springs.
(edit: these turned into really long ramblings, I really quite enjoyed the day)

I've never navigated/rogained in Australia before. So being made redundant and the cash payout meant I had time and resources available, the cash came in the day that Air New Zealand had a 48 Hour Sale to Australia, I booked a lot of tickets that day.

My goal was simply a full on training exercise, learning about the map style, terrain, planning, gear required and off course a good night session. I figured this was going to be as close as possible to the Alice Springs map and terrain that I'd get. Robert thought that was a good idea and popped over. I was pretty happy about that as I think he's one of the better and more organised planners so I'd get back to basics.

The map is 1:50,000 with 10m contours. The green on the map is meaningless but it did make the map look nicer. A lot of areas that were green were in fact open farm land and some areas that were white were actually the most difficult scrub. But nothing really mattered as you could take a straight line everywhere.

Planning - It's flat, GPS says we did 1300m, that seems about right, the biggest climb was only 150-200m. Initial look suggested a quick draw of a rough route to see how long the whole course might be. I drew a semi-random 103-5km, Robert drew one the opposite direction and came up with 95ish. We refined that, dropped some vert and both measured the new course at 94km (ish) in a straight line. We had gone over expecting that 90-100km (Straight line distance) would be possible WALKING, Robert is still walking and no running, so clearing the course was on. In previous Rogaines over there He and Phil have only ever covered that sort of distance but on tougher terrain, the 2007 Alice Springs map was also won in the 90km range???

Course -
Almost no one was running, a pair of Women jogged to the first and then off to the second control, they eventually came 3rd overall but their splits suggest they were walking from the 3rd control onwards. Two guys "ran" the first 3 controls with us as we walked, but no sign of anyone else running. The 2nd control for us (22-75) was straight into the technical difficulties of the map, very flat but accurate contours and trying to decipher what the streams on the map looked like. In general the marked streams were deep incised cuts, the longer the stream the deeper and more significant it was. However as always, there are other similar features that aren't on the map that do look like features that are on the map, although vague. Just about ALL the bush (Mallee) was open and FAST, even the thickest scrub wasn't difficult to penetrate. Visibility was good and at night you could pick a tree in the distance and go at that or on the open ground easily pick a hill top or saddle several Km's away and go at that for a long time. There were at least 2 controls during the day that we could see from 1.5km away, so maps down and just walk.

Early on we wondered if there might a map alignment error as 49-38-67 we ended up right of the control but maybe that was just getting used to the terrain as that didn't seem to crop up later. We made a minor blue from 45-71 going up the wrong water course, by this stage we knew the controls were perfectly placed so we just popped along the top of the hill to the correct gully and carried on. 56-82 we chased a team a bit hard up the hill maybe, and the first significant downhill saw Robert cramp from the change in load on his legs, I also smashed my phone. Fuck it. 1st Water stop came and we were 90 minutes ahead of schedule. The water stops had fruit which was always pleasant. The cramp never caused an issue as coming into night the pace was naturally going to ease up. We managed to get over to 85 before lighting up. The first dark leg had potential for issues so we took our time and nailed it, followed by another even more vague walk from 76-62, we hit the two dam/tank features along the way before picking up the correct water courses. 62-24 looks a bit wobbly but we just wanted to follow the spur down to the road.

55-63 was a minor error, hitting the 2nd railway track on the wrong side of the control, however we just back tracked from the junction. I was a touched tired by now, Friday I had left home at Midnight and driven to Christchurch, ended up being a 23 hour day then sleeping in a strange bed before a 24 hour rogaine.

Testing. 31-92-44 could have been a disaster in the dark. DEAD FLAT and dark. Intentionaly hit the stream SW of 92 then for 44, took a bearing to hit the dam, way in the back ground was a saddle on the correct line so used that to walk all the way to it balancing distance with the time taken to get to the dam. Hit 44 on the nose, shit, I might be learning something doing all this orienteering. I then proceeded to wobble all over the place to 21 with Robert taking the correct line.

78 was the only control that I think might not have been in the dead center of the circle. I think it was in the bottom of the SW stream rather than a fraction to the north. Splitting bloody hairs, the controls were so easy to see and this was only maybe 20m out, the controls were so well placed. Something for Major NZ events to work on.

91-83 shouldn't have been very difficult, but it was midnight and I was a bit wobbly. Robert lead us down but somehow I got in front and wandered of the ridge to the SW, Robert quickly picked that up but in hindsight we were one saddle short of the correct one and made a nice big mistake. As you can see on the map there are two saddles and to the north of them are nearly identical sets of water courses. We dropped down to the correct height and junction, couldn't see the controls and knew we were in the wrong place. Eventually working out that with no high ground to NNW of us we probably needed to go one gully to the West, so we did that BUT CLIMBED into it and got into the steep guts that are clearly marked on the maps. Deciding that our first gully actually looked better we returned to that and I even recall saying we are at 500m and not to climb any higher, that should have been a trigger to drop down to where the control was. Bugger. Couldn't find it, had lost 30 minutes so decided to leave. As we walked down not actually knowing 100% where we were just aiming at the road. The hills to our left then became clearer and we understood exactly where the control was, but by then it was another 20 minutes back to it. That would have cut our buffer to 30 minutes so we just carried on.

We quickly regrouped from that, although 43-61 could have gone to shit quite easily as we chose the road and there were no obvious attack points as the streams crossing it weren't that great. I got to have a quick nap at W2, could have been a minute could have been 5, I sparked up for a tiny bit. 57-47 could have been another disaster with a very similar line as 83 but we felt the hard line of a ridge was safer than the vague flat contours, GPS track says we nailed it. 50 we had originally planned from the other side, the marked road was really visible but the dead straight line suggested it was actually a fence. That is the case with a lot of the tracks on this map and I guess could be similar in Alice. The roads/tracks are almost certainly associated with a fence and the fence is often easier to see than the road. Looking at the map now, we should have gone straight from 50-81.

81-94 - I totally lost my marbles and had no idea where we were for the entire leg. I kept questioning Robert as I couldn't make anything fit especially from the Saddle we used to attack from. Robert nailed it perfectly and we turned our lights off. I went from a shit heap to wide awake in less than a minute.

The last really tricky leg was 33-41, vague as buggery. We couldn't really see the high points to our left and moving slowly by now (actually only 1min/km slower than we started) we thought we had moved a long way further to the east, got onto the middle track thinking it was the correct track. Just as we got worried we were parallel to the correct Dam and considering a look when Robert saw a team come out from behind.

Groveled around the last couple and finished 65 minutes early so didn't lose any time in the last 12 hours against the schedule.

Can't really thank the planners/setters and general team enough for the quality of the course. Sure it was short, but they planned and event for the people they thought might turn up. The controls were just so well placed and lots of really technical skills were used to get around. The area itself is full of Gold Mining History from the mid 1800s, I love that stuff so it was a real priviledge to go there.

Advice - who the hell am I to give advice, so maybe these are just things I picked up on.

Time/Distance/Terrain - we planned 95k walking and ignoring the error, 105km walking would have been

possible. The team who finished 2nd I think planned and even shorter route. If this was running, planning a course in the 130-140km range seems logical or as much as 160 (Chris). Talking to a few locals they think the terrain in Alice Spring will be rougher, by that I mean the under foot rocks. Some of it was quite hard on the feet and mine were sore and I wish I'd had shoes with a rock plate. The orgainsers for Worlds have written there is no need to cross the saddles on the map, so my guess is that it will be really really flat. I assume you've all seen the 2007 map of the area. I had a look at routes there and that was won with only about 90km straight line. Who knows, but I really do suspect that running will be a significant part of the event particularly if the attack points can been seen from 1-2km away.

Gear - Shit, I really wanted to find out about this spinifex plant. I did find one and they are horrible. But it was like a big horse shoe and really easy to step over. Talking to one guy he did say that shoe gaitors and leg gaitors would be needed. But I really have no idea as I never ever wear gaitors and am quite happy to get carved up so hearign you need gaitors from people who always wear gaitors is just hard for me to balance. I Don't know. Shoes, I do know that something with a good rock plate will be useful. Hopefully the model course will have enough to allow a choice to be made. I think I'll go over with options.

Tracks/Roads/Fences - the roads marked on our map were all there, but some were bloody vague due to the rock hard dry ground, they were almost always associated with a fence though and drifting left or right for 20m would find you the track or just follow a bearing.

On this map Dams were a significant feature that was used and were generally well marked, if it was on the map it could be found on the ground and used to navigate with, they all have big 2m+ walls and were easy to spot from a distance, Gates were also marked on the map although I didn't really pick up on that until the end, should have looked at the legend.

I'm sure I thought of other things that might be useful but can't remember and should really do some work.

The Map - Teslan Paper. This stuff is awesome, I highlighted our route and then just used the map as is, no coverseal, no plastic bag. A3 folded and unfolded to hand size all day and there is barely a mark on it. No loss of highlighter lines or loss of deatil on creases.

The dropbox link has a few photos and a pdf with three routes on it. It was a bloody nice day out in some really cool terrain, thanks Robert.

https://www.dropbox.com/sh/y875xs17zvhfagv/AAC4AEGXHra9mhV84CesEvDJa?dl=0